



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 1.2 MAPPING THE NATURAL NOTES ON THE FRETBOARD

Introduction: Understanding the Importance of Natural Notes

The natural notes on the guitar are the fundamental building blocks for understanding the fretboard. These notes are the "letter" notes (A, B, C, D, E, F, and G) without any sharps (#) or flats (b). They form the basis for scales, chords, and melodies. Learning to locate and map these notes on the fretboard is essential for developing fretboard fluency and becoming a more versatile guitarist.

In this lesson, we'll focus on mapping the natural notes across the entire fretboard and understanding their positions in relation to each other. By the end, you'll be able to quickly identify any natural note in multiple positions, setting the stage for more advanced concepts like intervals, scales, and chord construction.

Why Should You Map the Natural Notes?

Mapping the natural notes helps you:

1. **Navigate the Fretboard with Confidence:** Knowing the location of natural notes in various positions allows for easy fretboard navigation.
 2. **Build a Solid Foundation for Scales and Chords:** Most scales and chords are derived from the arrangement of natural notes.
 3. **Improve Your Improvisation and Compositional Skills:** When you know where the natural notes are, it's easier to create melodies and improvise.
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Step-by-Step Process for Mapping Natural Notes

Step 1: Understand the Basic Layout

The natural notes are spaced in a specific order: **A, B, C, D, E, F, G**. The distance between each note is either a **whole tone** (2 frets) or a **semitone** (1 fret).

Whole tones occur between:

- A to B
- C to D
- D to E
- F to G
- G to A



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Semitones occur between:

- B to C
- E to F

This means when moving from B to C or E to F on the fretboard, you move just one fret. For all other transitions between natural notes, move up or down two frets.

Step 2: Find the Natural Notes on the Low E and A Strings

The low E and A strings serve as a reference for finding natural notes across the fretboard. Start by memorizing the positions of the natural notes on these two strings:

1. Low E String (6th string):

- Open: E
- 1st fret: F
- 3rd fret: G
- 5th fret: A
- 7th fret: B
- 8th fret: C
- 10th fret: D
- 12th fret: E (Octave)

2. A String (5th string):

- Open: A
- 2nd fret: B
- 3rd fret: C
- 5th fret: D
- 7th fret: E
- 8th fret: F
- 10th fret: G
- 12th fret: A (Octave)



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Step 3: Map the Natural Notes Across All Strings Using Octave Shapes

Once you have the natural notes on the E and A strings, use octave shapes to find them on the D, G, and B strings. For example:

- **From the E string:** Move down two strings and up two frets to find the same note (octave).
 - E (12th fret, 6th string) -> E (14th fret, 4th string)
- **From the A string:** Move down two strings and up two frets.
 - A (12th fret, 5th string) -> A (14th fret, 3rd string)

Practice finding octaves to connect natural notes across the fretboard.

Step 4: Practice Finding Natural Notes in Different Positions

1. **Play through the notes on a single string:**
 - Start from an open string and play each natural note in ascending order until you reach the octave. For example, on the A string: A, B, C, D, E, F, G, A.
2. **Play through the notes across multiple strings:**
 - Start with a note on the low E string, then find the same note on the A, D, G, B, and high E strings. This will help you see how the note is distributed across the neck.
3. **Use visual aids like diagrams or charts** to memorize the positions until you can find the natural notes without looking.

Step 5: Practice Exercises to Reinforce Note Recognition

1. **Exercise 1: Finding Natural Notes Using Fretboard Diagrams**
 - Print or draw a blank fretboard diagram and fill in all the natural notes. Use it as a reference to test yourself until you can complete it from memory.
2. **Exercise 2: Note Location Practice**
 - Choose a random natural note (e.g., D) and find it in all positions across the fretboard. Repeat with each natural note until you can locate them instantly.
3. **Exercise 3: Naming Notes While Playing**
 - As you play scales or chords, name each note aloud. This helps reinforce the visual and auditory connection to the fretboard.
4. **Exercise 4: Interval Practice Using Natural Notes**
 - Choose a root note (e.g., C) and find all natural note intervals (e.g., major 3rd = E, perfect 5th = G, etc.) to see the relationship between notes.